



The Black Pearl of Poultry

DEVOTED CONNOISSEURS OF non-vegetarian Indian cuisine, who scoff at the very mention of chicken, fall into a reverential awe at the mention of the Kadaknath chicken. Originally a wild fowl from the Dhar and Jhabua regions in Madhya Pradesh, the *Kadaknath* is a heritage breed with an enigmatic aura. Its striking appearance—jet-black feathers that gleam like obsidian and distinctly dark flesh—has earned it the local moniker *kali masi*, or the Black Pearl of Poultry. Its authenticity is so valued that it received the coveted geographical indication tag in 2018. A key aspect of its rarity is its resistance to industrial-scale production. “These are slow-growing birds that require large, free-range environments and a natural feed to develop their unique meat texture and nutritional profile,” explains Raja Singh of RB Farms, a *Kadaknath* breeder from Delhi. Available at ₹1,200 per kg, the fowl’s real value lies in its exceptional nutrition. Its dark, lean meat is rich in protein and iron. Gourmands celebrate its complex flavour profile—“a taste at once robust and delicate, holding whispers of wild game,” describes Dhruv Oberoi, executive chef of Delhi’s Olive restaurant. This is complemented by famed medicinal qualities; it is traditionally believed to strengthen vitality, boost immunity, and aid recovery. To eat it is to partake of authentic tribal wisdom. On fine-dining menus, its presence signals discernment. A choice not just of meat, but of narrative, provenance and purity.